

The Signaling Gap:

State-Owned Media and the Strategic Management of Sentiment during the Russian Invasion of Ukraine

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Political Science



Photo: REUTERS/Carlos Barria February 24, 2022

The Bind

Your treaty ally just invaded
a sovereign state.

You can't condemn them —
they guarantee your
security.

You can't stay silent — the
West is watching.



Photo: UN Photo/Mark Garten February, 25 2022

The Hidden Channel



We think state media is for the masses. The CIA thinks it's for them.

The Gap

Academics

- Agenda setting & framing
- Spin dictators & censorship
- Domestic opinion formation

Practitioners

- Window into regime preferences
- Shifts in tone = policy signals
- 80+ years of institutional practice

We formalize what practitioners have known

Why the Signal Works

Readable

Everyone knows state media is state-controlled. Deviation is informative.

Costly

Negative coverage of your patron risks retaliation from Moscow.

Deniable

"We don't control the press." Institutional separation protects the relationship.

Data & Design

174K

Articles

11 countries, 62 sources

GPT-4o

Sentiment

F1 = .92 vs. human coders

RD

In Time

Feb, 24 2022 as cutoff

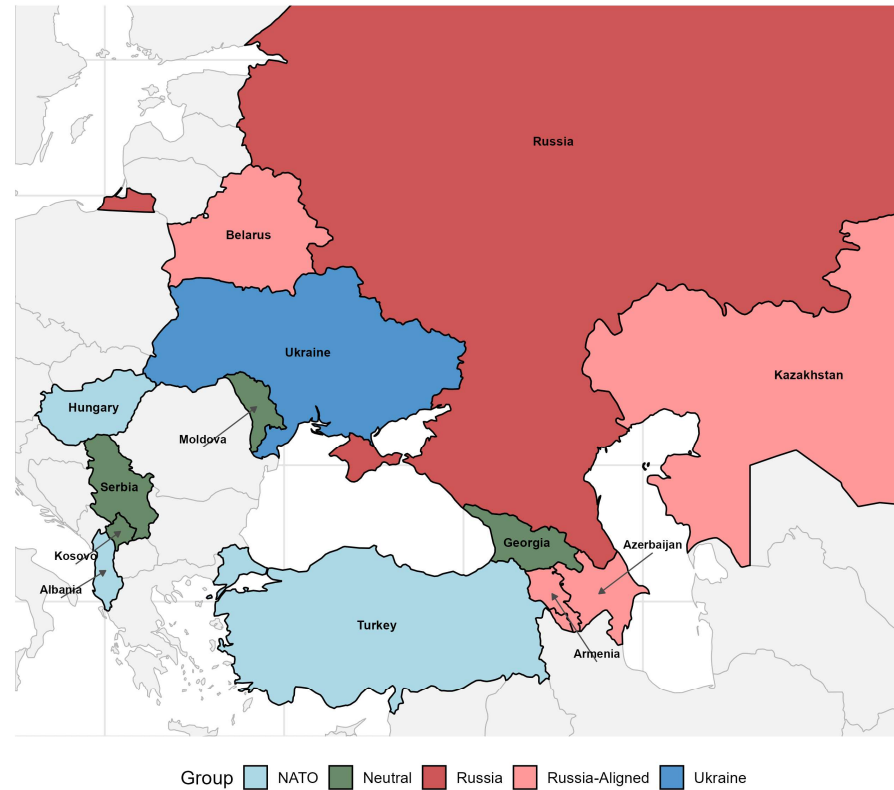
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Groups

Russia-aligned, Neutral, NATO

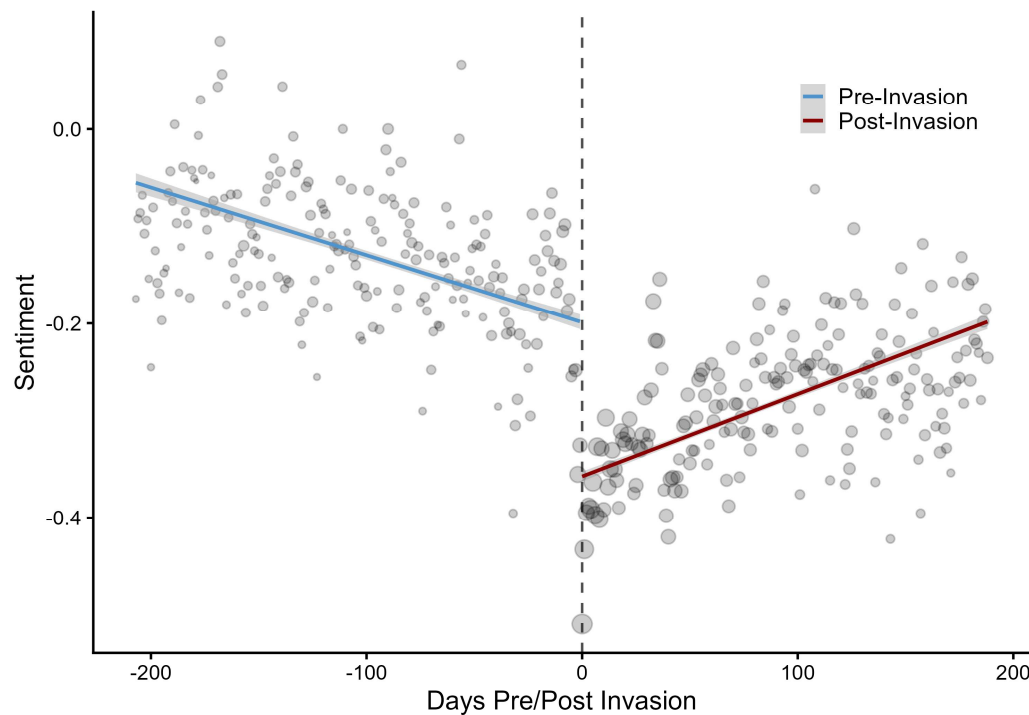
The Countries

Study Region: Russia's Near Abroad



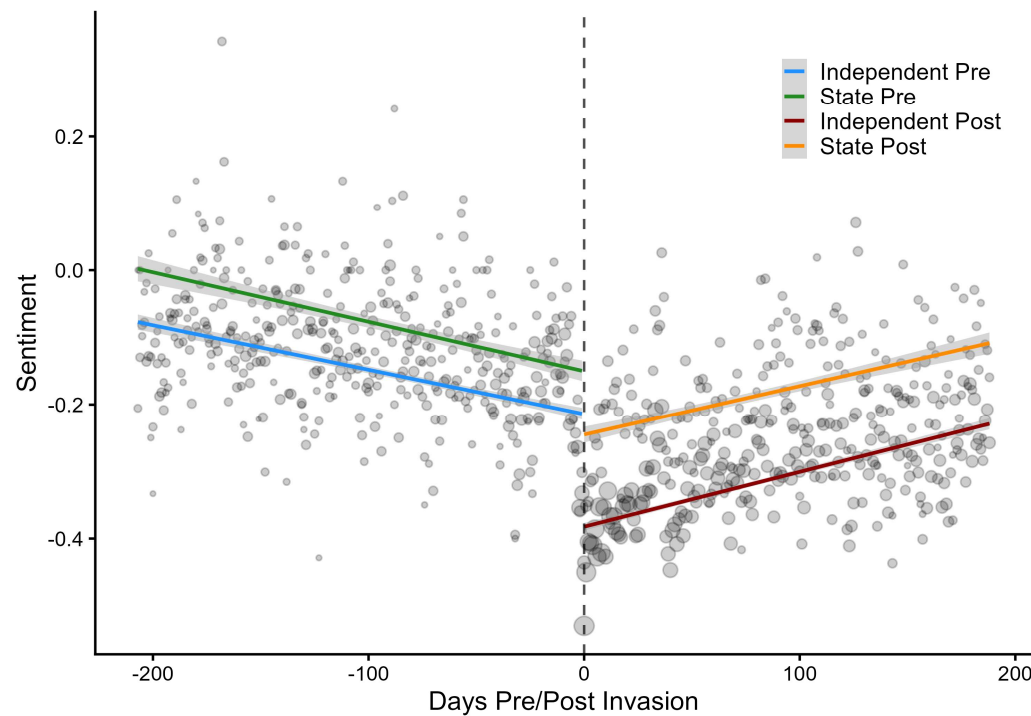
The Shock

The invasion produced a sharp negative shock across all media.



State Media is Different

State media responded less negatively than independent media.



Two Predictions

Domestic Propaganda

Suppress negative coverage to protect the alliance →

Russia-aligned state media should be the *least* negative.

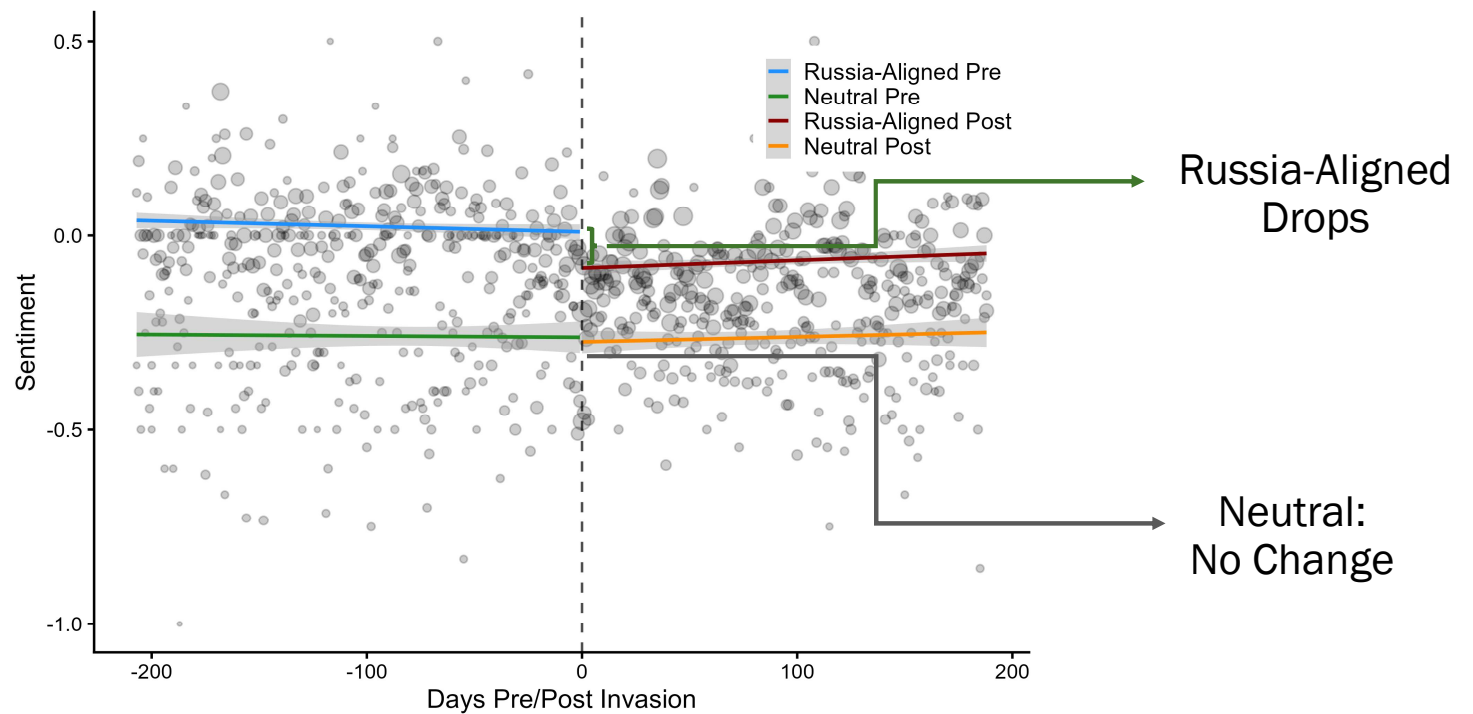
Signaling

Amplify through informal channels because formal ones are locked →

Russia-aligned state media should be the *most* negative.

The Counterintuitive Finding

Russia's allies went more negative — not less.



Beyond International Relations

Constrained communication is universal. When formal channels are blocked, actors find informal ones — in any hierarchy, not just international relations.

The theory-practice gap is a method. What do practitioners in your field know that we haven't studied yet?

LLMs unlock questions at scale. 174K articles, one model, .92 accuracy — this wasn't possible five years ago.

Thank You

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